one direction—a victory for the Modi-led NDA. Only the scale of the win differed.

ABP News predicted 281 seats for the NDA, NDTV 280, TV Today 261 to 283, India TV 289, CNN-IBN 274 to 286. Times Now was the only channel to suggest a hung Parliament with a figure of 249 to the NDA, while News 24 was the outlier—their poll predicted a massive 340 seats to the NDA. All polls predicted the Congress-led UPA struggling to cross the 100-seat mark.

The News 24 poll (which would eventually come closest to reality) was done by someone called Today's Chanakya. This esoteric sounding gent who had named himself after the canny ancient scholar was, a little more prosaically, a certain V.K. Bajaj. I had first him met more than a decade ago, during the 2003 Rajasthan elections. He was from Bikaner and had come to see me with a packet of the town's famous *bhujia*.

'Sir, Vasundhara is winning the elections. I have an interest in predicting elections, please give me one chance!' he told me. I took the bhujia but was a little dismissive of his claims to be a pollster. He thrust a piece of paper in my hand with his findings. They turned out to be pretty accurate. Every time there was an election, he'd SMS or email me his numbers. More often than not, they were right (yes, he got some wrong too!). I asked him what his trade secret was, especially since he didn't have a sample size for his poll. He'd just smile and say, 'I have my nose to the ground, sir!' VK, as I called him, was proof that no one had a monopoly on being a successful pollster. No wonder people in India take the *satta* market seriously too!

One of the other problems with exit polls is quite simply this—the winning politician comes on air and praises your poll, the loser calls you biased. The 12th of May was no different. The Congress, in fact, had gone so far as to say that the exit polls were rigged and unscientific, and none of their leaders would participate in a TV debate on the findings.

The BJP leaders were predictably ecstatic, while the so-called third or fourth front leaders were a little nonplussed. 'You may have no role now to play,' I told Derek O'Brien of the Trinamool. 'Let's wait till the 16th, then Mamatadi will show her cards,' was his measured response. The exit polls